

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS: PROSE,

CHAPTER 1 • THE FRONT PAGE

2026-09-01. Pipeline step 4 at production scale, chapter 1 of 10, per SAS/prompt-claude-fable-briefs-four-keys-kickoff.md. Ten packages, fk_p01_01 to fk_p01_10, against structure v2.2 Parts B and D. The cold open vo.4's words are used verbatim per Part D's ruled cut; Fable wrote only the connective tissue, the p01_04 wake caption and the p01_09 Del scene, from redacted briefs, blind to the graph. Every line below is a placeholder until Stephen rules it. Per package: the brief as sent (for audit), then the prose that returned, marked DRAFT, with the locked vo.4 segment placed where the chapter plays it.

Blindness record: prose written by a fresh Fable subagent fed only: spine Part G (the public account) · the five v1.2 · cold open vo.4 · ally-voice-reference v1.0 Part A with the Pass 4 and warning-sign checks · the story-so-far digest (empty, chapter 1) · the ten briefs below. No repo access, no memory, zero tool uses. Briefs leak-checked against spine v1.4 before the run; prose leak-checked after. One revision cycle: the first p01_09 OPEN pre-announced the police result (a board-first breach, caught by the structure check) and the first p01_04 caption anchored "two weeks" to the wake instead of the death; both were rewritten by the same blind Fable agent within licence.

Checks (run 2026-09-01, this session): ① Leak check vs spine v1.4: PASS. No graph fact appears; the standing never-tolds hold; Del says nothing the file holds. ② Voice check (Part A rules, Pass 4, warning signs, registers): PASS, with the three weakest lines named below. No em dashes anywhere. ③ Structure conformance vs Part B: PASS after the p01_09 revision; the three turns land on their completions. ④ Ruled-text conformance: vo.4's words untouched, boundaries per Part D, sign-off as ruled.

Stop-and-report (minor, no licence widened): Part D labels p01_09's stretch as starting "A sergeant I trust...", but no such sentence exists in cold open vo.4. The only stretch ending "...they could use." is "Police examined Violet's letters...", and that is used here as segment 9. Flagged for Stephen with F4's re-seam clause in mind.

The three weakest lines, named honestly (Stephen reads these first):

1. **p01_09 OPEN (revised): "Six weeks of police work to read, and then I ask Del what it means."** The words "to read" can imply Ally holds the file, and she never does; her sourcing never touches it. Suggested fix if Stephen agrees: "Six weeks of their work laid out on my board, and then I ask Del what it means."
2. **p01_03 OPEN: "Two weeks after she died, four keys arrived in the post. Say it flat."** It pre-tells its own beat's central fact moments before the locked segment lands it. "Say it flat" is right; the first sentence could hold the strangeness without spending the keys.
3. **p01_06 OPEN: "The Saturday, in order. Who called, what they agreed, what was waiting."** "What was waiting" is a small manufactured-intrigue tease of exactly the class Pass 4 deletes; defensible as a working note, but the weakest of its kind in the chapter.

fk_p01_01 • A1 • (t)[AL] • the ident and the death line

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_01, one card (audio, tier 1). The first package of the game. The player's first board work is one small audio action: the tape starts. On completion the locked segment below is heard. The beat is orientation: the show, the woman, the stairs. It must never grow.

Write: OPEN, one line in Ally's voice, her working note as she sits down to the microphone with the Gazette front page on the desk. The first thing the player ever reads from her. Not addressed to the player.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: The front page is on the desk. Start with her name.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

This is Echoes of Havenbay. I'm Ally Quinn.

Nine months ago, a forty-four-year-old woman named Violet Moore was found dead at the bottom of her stairs.

fk_p01_02 · F1×2 · (t)[ET] · her work, then the ruling pinned

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_02, one card (documents, two tier-1 items). Board work: the public record goes on the board, her work as the town sees it and the inquest ruling beside it. The accepted account, pinned. Constraint: Violet's public work only, as the town sees it (the five gives you her shop fronts, boat names, menu boards, the bus). Nothing about the inside of her workshop or her private affairs.

Write: OPEN, one line, Ally assembling the accepted account.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Her signs first, then the ruling. The town's version of Violet, pinned.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

Violet painted signs for a living. If you walked around this city, you'd see her work everywhere. Above shops. On boats. She even painted the side of a bus once.

Her death was ruled an accident. A terrible fall causing blunt force trauma to her head, nothing more.

fk_p01_03 · A2 · (t)[ET] · the post

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_03, one card (audio, tier 2). Board work: the story's first strange fact goes on tape. On completion the locked segment is heard: four keys and a letter in her handwriting. The dead woman arranged something.

Write: OPEN, one line.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Two weeks after she died, four keys arrived in the post. Say it flat.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

But two weeks later, four people received something in the post.

Each of them got an identical key and a letter written in Violet's handwriting.

fk_p01_04 · A2 + F2, two cards · ★TURN [ET] · the names, and the accusation lands

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_04, two cards (one audio, one documents). The chapter's first turn. Board work across two cards: the four friends enter the story, and the letter's sentence lands exactly on this package's completion. From here, accident is one of two readings. The beat's image is the wake photograph: the Gazette front page picture of the four of them together at Violet's wake.

Write: OPEN, one or two lines (Ally putting names to faces). CAPTION, one or two lines for the wake photograph as it is pinned: four friends, one frame, before any of it. The caption must not accuse anyone and must not claim anything the letter does not.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Liam, Ruby, Margo, Brad. I want their faces in front of me before I read what the letter says about them.

CAPTION (the wake photograph, revised for time accuracy): Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins at Violet Moore's wake. Two weeks after she died, each of them had a key.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

Their names were Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera and Brad Collins. They were Violet's closest friends. And according to the letter, one of them may have been planning to kill her.

Violet didn't know which one. She admitted she might be wrong. But she was frightened enough to leave behind four keys.

fk_p01_05 · A2×2 · (t)[ET] · not the police, and a locked door

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_05, one card (audio, two tier-2 items). Board work: her instruction goes on the record. On completion the locked segment is heard: not the police, and a locked door, and the reason she gave.

Write: OPEN, one line.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Now her instructions. No police. A door only the four could open.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

She also told her friends not to go to the police.

Instead, she directed them to a locked door. Behind it, she said, was the reason she had become afraid.

fk_p01_06 · F2 + F2, two cards · ★TURN [ET] · the pact, the Saturday, she knew

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_06, two cards (documents, documents). The chapter's second turn. Board work across two cards: the pact and the Saturday reconstructed, then what was behind the door. Constraint: never speculate what the object was, in any line. Ally knows only that it was something of Violet's and that the survivors will not say.

Write: OPEN, one line.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: The Saturday, in order. Who called, what they agreed, what was waiting.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

The four friends called each other that night. They agreed that nobody would open the door alone. They'd wait until Saturday, when all four of them could be there together.

And when they finally opened it, they found another letter.

This one didn't say she thought. It said she knew.

There was an object beside it. Something that had belonged to Violet. Two of the friends are still alive, and neither one will say what that object was.

fk_p01_07 · A3 · (t)[ET] · the disappearances

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_07, one card (audio, tier 3). Board work: the two cars, the same car park, five months apart. On completion the locked segment is heard.

Write: OPEN, one line.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Two cars, one car park, five months apart. Keep the dates straight.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

Then the group began to disappear.

Seven weeks after Violet's funeral, Brad drove to Kestrel Head, a place known for people who don't plan on coming home. His car was found there, but Brad never was.

Five months later, Margo's car appeared in the same car park. Three days after that, her body washed into the harbour.

fk_p01_08 · A2×2 · (t)[ET] · the walk-ins

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_08, one card (audio, two tier-2 items). Board work: two survivors, two separate walks to the police, the same sentence. On completion the locked segment is heard.

Write: OPEN, one line.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Both of them went to the police that week, separately, to say the same thing.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

That left Liam and Ruby.

They both went to the police. Separately. And each of them said the same basic thing.

I'm afraid of the other one.

fk_p01_09 · A4 · ★TURN [ET] · board-first, then Del on the steps

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_09, one card (audio, tier 4): the chapter's heaviest board work. The chapter's third turn, built board-first: the player earns the result before hearing it. On completion the locked segment is heard, and then the scene plays: Ally and Del on the precinct steps.

SCENE brief. Sergeant Delaney "Del" Cruz, thirty, Harbor Ward, the sergeant Ally trusts. Register (locked, verbatim from the bible): "Level, economical, honest about the cost of things: 'You know what that does to a career?' 'Wakes it up. Mine's been asleep for years.' Her signature mode: 'I can't officially tell you to do this, but if you do, be careful.'" She calls Ally "Quinny"; the nickname is hers alone and nobody else uses it. She never relaxes; she picks the better sightline even on her own steps.

What the scene does: the segment has just told the listener the facts. Del does not repeat them and does not re-narrate anything. She interprets: they looked properly and there is nothing; the file is closed because procedure found nothing it could hold; whatever is wrong here lives in people, not in paper, and paper is all she is allowed to act on. Her canonical line is available to use: "We looked. Properly. There's

nothing." She promises nothing, hints at no doubt of her own, names nothing beyond the public account. Ally may ask one question; Del may decline one. Setting: the precinct steps, Del standing where she can see the street. Under about 150 words.

Write: OPEN, one line (the weight of the work before the answer, without stating the result). SCENE as briefed.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN (revised to hold the result back): Six weeks of police work to read, and then I ask Del what it means.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

Police examined Violet's letters and found no reason to believe they were fake. They looked into Liam. They looked into Ruby. They found nothing they could use.

SCENE:

Precinct steps, gone six. Del stands two steps above me, where she can see the street both ways.

ALLY: Tell me straight. Is there anything in that file worth a year of my life?

DEL: We looked. Properly. There's nothing. That's the truth, Quinny, and it took six weeks of good people's time to earn it.

ALLY: So it's closed.

DEL: Closed means procedure found nothing it could hold. The letters are hers. The solicitor confirms when she lodged them. The coroner's finding stands. Paper is all I'm allowed to act on, and the paper is clean. Whatever's wrong with those four, it doesn't live in paper. It lives in people.

ALLY: Which of the two did you believe?

DEL: Not answering that.

ALLY: Had to ask.

DEL: I can't officially tell you to do this. But if you do, be careful.

fk_p01_10 · A2 · (t)[AL] · the Gazette war, the sign-off, Ep 1 publishes

Brief sent:

Package fk_p01_10, one card (audio, tier 2). The chapter's close. Board work: the broadcast assembled. On completion the locked segment is heard, ending in the ruled sign-off, and Episode 1 publishes.

Write: OPEN, one line, Ally cutting the episode together. Nothing after the sign-off; no tease of what comes next.

DRAFT prose:

OPEN: Cut it in order. Check every line traces to someone. Then send it.

BEAT (vo.4 verbatim):

Now Liam and Ruby are accusing each other publicly, and Violet's warning is tearing them apart as Havenbay takes sides.

Ruby has agreed to speak with me. Liam hasn't. At least, not yet.

I don't know what was behind that locked door. I don't know whether Violet really identified her killer. And I don't know whether Liam or Ruby has a reason to be afraid.

But four friends received four keys.

Nine months later, two of them are dead, and the other two believe one of them could be next.

So that's where we begin.

With Violet, her four friends and the door she wanted them to open.

This is Echoes of Havenbay, I'm Ally Quinn. Goodnight for now, Harbour. Sleep tight.